

Nehru Stadium in Chennai.

The match had ended 2-1 in their favour, NorthEast United was knocked out of the ISL playoffs, the hosts were almost in, and Tamil songs blared out of the boombox as players danced with fans in front of the team bus.

Cut to March 2025, Chennaiyin — already out of the knockouts race — is annihilated 0-3 by NorthEast United at the same venue, with only a handful of home fans perched on the stands, giving flashbacks to empty stadiums during the pandemic.

The lull outside the stadium was a stark contrast to that around this time last year. Coyle, the gaffer, looked dejected. So did the players. And the boombox was carried out of the dressing room in funereal silence. Winter had come for House Chennaiyin on a Monday night, and it had Alaaeddine Ajaraie written on the back of his shirt.

The Moroccan scored once, assisted twice and almost bagged another goal, only to be denied by the woodwork. With 21 goals and seven assists, he now has more goal contributions than any player ever in a single ISL season.

“To get a player like Ajaraie, who’s a difference-maker, anybody in the league would crave having a (striker who can score) 21 goals. You can probably strike him as somebody who creates and works hard for his team. I think he’s been a revelation this year,” Coyle said after the match.

This *Aladdin* does not have a flying carpet or a fancy lamp, but he does have magic, one that left Coyle’s army shell-shocked and the travelling fans in seventh heaven.

Memory is a fickle element in football — that was NorthEast United’s lesson in 2024, it will be Chennaiyin’s this year.

Neeladri Bhattacharjee

Hoping for a Super comeback

After failing to make the ISL playoffs, the Kerala Blasters (right) has now decided to focus on the Super Cup, which begins in Bhubaneswar on April 21.

The Blasters had a disappointing



season but still managed a stunning win over defending ISL champion Mumbai City FC in their last home game in Kochi, after which they were in eighth place with a match to go. And interim coach T.G.

Purushothaman is hopeful that the Super Cup will offer his team a fresh start.

“The Super Cup is a competition where we can show our character and end the season on a positive note. The focus is to improve and ensure we come back stronger,” said Purushothaman. Looking back on the season, Purushothaman — who had come into the spotlight after the team’s Swedish head coach Mikael Stahre was sacked mid-December — admitted that his side lacked consistency but also said that some refereeing decisions affected the

On song: With 21 goals and seven assists, Alaaeddine Ajaraie has more goal contributions than any player ever in a single ISL season. FSDL/ISL MEDIA

Blasters.

“This season had both positives and disappointments. We showed quality in many games, controlled possession, and created chances, but we lacked consistency in converting performances into results,” he said.

“Injuries and some tough moments affected us, some refereeing decisions in crucial moments went against us but we take responsibility as a team. The key now is to learn from this and come back stronger.”

Stan Rayan

